The OTP Trap: A UPI Phishing Scam Case Study

Rohan, a college student in Bhopal, received a message claiming to be from his bank. The message said his account would be blocked unless he verified it immediately. It included a link that looked like the official banking website.

When Rohan clicked the link, he was taken to a fake website that looked exactly like his bank's login page. He entered his UPI ID and password. Within seconds, he received an OTP on his phone. The fake site prompted him to enter the OTP for "verification."

Without realizing the risk, Rohan entered the OTP. In reality, scammers were using his credentials to initiate a UPI transaction. The OTP acted as authorization, and ₹25,000 was instantly transferred from his account.

How the crime happens :

1. Victim receives fake SMS/email (phishing message)
2. Clicks malicious link
3. Enters sensitive details (UPI ID, password)
4. Receives OTP
5. Shares OTP unknowingly
6. Money gets transferred instantly

Who is targeted:

- Students and young users
- People unfamiliar with cyber security
- Elderly individuals
- Frequent online banking users

Consequences:

- Financial loss
- Emotional stress and panic
- Risk of identity theft
- Loss of trust in digital systems